

Chapter 27: What He Brings Back

Austin didn't return the same way he left.

Not exactly.

Jenny noticed it immediately.

It wasn't obvious.

It never was with him.

But something about the way he stood at the counter felt... more certain.

Like distance hadn't loosened him.

It had clarified him.

Jenny wiped her hands on her apron.

"You're staring again," she said without looking up.

"I'm not staring."

"You are."

A pause.

Then—

"I'm observing."

Jenny finally looked at him.

"Same thing."

"No," he said calmly. "Not anymore."

That made her frown.

"...What does that mean?"

Austin didn't answer immediately.

Instead, he leaned slightly against the counter.

"I used to observe to understand," he said.

Jenny crossed her arms.

"And now?"

"Now I observe because I already understand enough."

That landed differently.

Jenny didn't like how steady that sounded.

Too settled.

Too decided.

"You're being cryptic," she muttered.

"I'm being honest."

"That's worse."

A faint exhale from him.

Almost amusement.

But it didn't fully appear.

Jenny sighed.

"You're in a strange mood today."

"I've been thinking," he said.

"I noticed."

"That's the problem."

Jenny blinked.

"...Excuse me?"

Austin looked at her directly.

"The more I think, the less I want to go back to how things were before I met you."

That sentence didn't surprise her anymore.

But it still landed too deeply.

Jenny looked away for a second.

Then back.

"You say that like it's simple."

"It's not simple," he corrected.

"Then stop saying it like it is."

A pause.

Then softer—

"I say it like it's necessary."

Jenny hesitated.

"...Necessary for what?"

Austin didn't answer immediately.

Then—

"For me to stay the same in a way that includes you."

Jenny frowned slightly.

"That doesn't make sense."

"It does to me."

Of course it did.

It always did with him.

Jenny exhaled.

"You're making everything about me now."

"No," he said. "I'm including you."

That distinction made her pause.

Including.

Not replacing.

Not consuming.

Including.

It felt different.

She didn't know if she liked that.

That afternoon, the restaurant was unusually calm.

Austin stayed seated.

Jenny found herself checking on him less.

Not because she stopped noticing.

But because noticing had become automatic.

Like background noise she no longer questioned.

Bao leaned toward her during a quiet moment.

"He's different again."

Jenny didn't look up.

"He's always different."

"No," Bao said. "This one feels final."

Jenny frowned slightly.

"What does that even mean?"

Bao shrugged.

"It means he's not figuring you out anymore."

That made her pause.

"...Then what is he doing?"

Bao smiled.

"Choosing."

Jenny didn't respond.

But something in her chest tightened anyway.

Later, Jenny finally walked over to him.

"You're leaving again?" she asked.

Austin looked up.

"I will."

"When?"

"Soon."

She crossed her arms.

"That's not an answer."

"It's the truth."

Jenny studied him.

"You're saying things differently now."

"Yes."

"Why?"

A pause.

Then honestly—

"Because I stopped waiting for clarity to come first."

Jenny frowned.

"...And now?"

Austin met her eyes.

"Now I act on what I already know."

That sentence lingered longer than it should have.

Jenny shifted slightly.

"And what do you know?"

Austin didn't hesitate.

"That I don't want distance from you anymore."

Silence.

Jenny's breath caught slightly.

She recovered quickly.

"Don't say things like that in a restaurant."

A faint pause.

Then—

"Then where should I say them?"

Jenny opened her mouth.

Closed it again.

No answer came.

Because there wasn't a safe place for that sentence.

Not really.

Austin stood slowly.

"I'll go," he said.

Jenny nodded too quickly.

"Good."

But he didn't leave immediately.

Instead, he looked at her one last time.

Not intense.

Not heavy.

Just steady.

Then he said quietly,

"I'm not stepping back anymore, Jenny."

And this time...

It didn't sound like a warning.

It sounded like direction.

Then he left.

Jenny stood there for a long moment.

Because something about the way he said it...

Made it feel like she had just been included in a decision she hadn't fully agreed to yet.

And worse...

She didn't feel like arguing it anymore.